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ACCESSIBLE HEALTHCARE

Healthcare services in India suffer from the problem of too many patients and too few doctors. According to recent surveys, there is only one government allopathic doctor for every 10,189 Indians. An online clinic, iCliniq, is helping citizens gain access to online consultations via messages, calls and videos, to address urgent medical concerns. DocsApp is another that allows you to consult a doctor online 24x7. Additionally, the app allows you to get diagnostic tests done from the comfort of your home – the company will send someone to your house to collect samples and the diagnostic reports will be accessible directly on the app.



DocsApp provides you with medical advice at home.

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TRAFFIC!

No matter who you are and no matter where you live, you hate traffic. We all do. With number of vehicles expected to double from existing numbers by as early as 2040, it's obvious that we need a solution to our traffic woes. Siemens Mobility has built a prototype monitoring system that utilises AI and traffic cameras to detect traffic density. Traffic lights are adjusted in a way to ease congestion. It's got a long way to go before it can be deployed though. Zipgo is a startup that provides point-to-point AC shuttle vehicles or services from more than 50 locations in Bengaluru. The vehicles provided are usually tempos and can be booked pretty easily through an app. The idea is that instead of individuals in cars, the more affluent can be coaxed to use this type of public transportation.

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OIL PRICES

In 2018, petrol prices surged to around ₹82 at one point in time. Many companies are looking to find feasible alternatives such as ethanol. In India, SpiceJet flew its first test flight powered by bio jet fuel. Two Indian companies, Bajaj and TVS, have also come up with motor-bikes that can run on bio-ethanol only.

About 280 litres of ethanol can be produced from one tonne of rice straw, which makes it a viable alternative to petroleum and other fuels in India.

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ILLITERACY

India's literacy rates are still pretty low at 74.04 per cent. However, over the past few years, there has been an overwhelmingly high number of ed-tech startups beginning to address the illiteracy issue in India. Plastic Water Labs is attempting to combat the problem of poor comprehension in students which causes them to drop out. They have introduced VR (virtual reality) learning as a solution since it increases spatial thinking due to it

being multi-sensory. With a monthly subscription fee of ₹350, students can learn science and math on any Android-based smartphone. Another startup, GyanLabs tackles the issue of overcrowding in classes where some students feel neglected by taking on a personalised, mobile-based learning approach, which adapts to what the student already knows and how they learn best. It is available in English and other vernacular mediums with a monthly fee of ₹199-349.

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CASH TRANSACTIONS

Demonetisation reminded us how dependent all of us were on cash. This also led to the popularisation of platforms such as PayTM and Google Pay. Other fintech startups are also trying to end cash dependency. As an example, the peer-to-peer payment app called Chillr allows you to transfer money directly from all of your bank accounts, and even performs other payment tasks such as recharging your phone, paying bills and more.

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DRINKING WATER

In India, close to 2,000 people, children under five being the most vulnerable, die every day due to lack of clean or drinkable water. Boiling water or buying bottled

water is too expensive. Scientists from Lucknow-based Indian Institute of Toxicology Research have developed a technology called Oneer for disinfecting water at just 2 paise per litre! The scientific principle of anodic oxidation is used to clean the water. The model can provide 10 litres of purified water in just five minutes and one full charge of the battery.

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CRIME AND THEFT

A technology startup, iCaptura, utilises CCTV cameras installed in cities to identify a repeat felon or terrorist. Another such example is Staqu. The Dubai Police has teamed up with Staqu, an Indian startup for their AI-based solution on predictive policing. It uses AI to analyse large amounts of data from various sources (devices, CCTV footage and more) in real-time to stop crimes in real time, or even before they happen. For example, if someone records a mugging, the next time cameras catch the mugger in an area, security forces are alerted and the offender can be arrested on sight.

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FAKE NEWS

While millions use WhatsApp to stay connected with family and friends, many of us fall victim to fake news. To address this pressing issue, WhatsApp, ahead of the 2019 general elections, launched a tip line for its users where they could report fake news. WhatsApp has partnered with PROTO, an Indian startup, which will create a database of rumours that will help in future studies of misinformation during elections and can provide technological solutions to prevent it. Additionally, it gets in touch with the user who sent the piece of uncertain information and inform them if the news or media is fake or not. PROTO can verify the authenticity of photos, videos and news in English and four other regional languages.

While some of these technologies and products are not foolproof yet, they combat real, pressing issues in our country. It is being seen that startups are letting go of the idea of duplicating western startup successes and are catering to the issues faced in India. 